

Initial Project Description

Gesture-Controlled Music Player Interface (Spotify)

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Course: Human-Computer Interaction

Date: January 24, 2026

1. Project Objective

Traditional music player interfaces rely heavily on conventional input devices such as keyboards, mice, and touchscreens, which can limit usability in specific contexts where hands-free operation is beneficial or necessary. This project aims to explore an alternative human-computer interaction paradigm by developing a gesture-controlled music player interface that enables users to control music playback using hand gestures captured through a webcam, eliminating the need for physical contact with input devices.

The primary objective is to investigate how natural hand gestures can serve as an intuitive and accessible interaction modality for music control. This approach addresses several usability challenges: it enables hands-free operation for users engaged in other activities (e.g., cooking, exercising, or working), improves accessibility for users with mobility impairments who may find traditional input devices challenging, and explores the potential for more natural, embodied interaction with digital media systems.

The intended user interaction involves performing predefined hand gestures within the webcam's field of view to execute common music player commands. The usage context encompasses scenarios where traditional input methods are inconvenient, unavailable, or less desirable, such as during physical activities, multitasking situations, or when maintaining hygiene (avoiding contact with shared devices). By focusing on gesture-based interaction, this project contributes to the broader HCI research area of natural user interfaces and touchless interaction design.

2. Input / Output Specification

Input: The system's primary input consists of real-time video frames captured by a standard webcam. These frames are processed to detect and track hand movements and specific hand gestures performed by the user. The input processing pipeline involves continuous monitoring of the video stream, identification of hand landmarks and positions, and recognition of predefined gesture patterns. The system is designed to operate under typical indoor lighting conditions and requires the user's hand(s) to be visible within the camera's field of view.

Output: The system generates two categories of output:

1. **Music Playback Actions:** Based on recognized gestures, the system executes corresponding music player commands, including:
 - Play/Pause toggle
 - Next track navigation
 - Previous track navigation
 - Volume increase/decrease
 - Mute/unmute functionality
2. **Visual Feedback:** The user interface provides real-time visual feedback to enhance usability and confirm gesture recognition:
 - Display of currently detected hand landmarks and tracking status
 - Visual confirmation of recognized gestures
 - Current playback status (track information, play/pause state, volume level)
 - Gesture instruction overlay or help panel for user guidance

The output design prioritizes immediate responsiveness and clear feedback to ensure users understand the system's state and the results of their gestural input.

3. Planned Functionality

The gesture-controlled music player will implement the following core functionalities:

Gesture Detection and Recognition: The system will utilize computer vision techniques to detect hand presence, track hand landmarks in real-time, and classify specific hand gestures. A predefined gesture vocabulary will be established, mapping distinct hand configurations and movements to music control commands. The gesture set will be designed for distinctiveness (to minimize false positives) and naturalness (to align with intuitive user expectations).

Gesture-to-Command Mapping: Each recognized gesture will be mapped to a specific music player function:

- **Open palm (static):** Play/Pause toggle
- **Swipe right:** Next track
- **Swipe left:** Previous track
- **Thumb up:** Volume increase
- **Thumb down:** Volume decrease
- **Fist (closed hand):** Mute/unmute

This mapping prioritizes learnability by selecting gestures that have semantic or metaphorical connections to their associated functions.

Real-Time Responsiveness: The system will be optimized for low-latency gesture recognition to ensure that the time between gesture execution and system response is

minimized (target: <500ms). This responsiveness is critical for maintaining the perception of direct manipulation and preventing user frustration.

Intuitive User Experience: The interface will include:

- **Onboarding tutorial:** Brief introduction to available gestures and their functions
- **Visual gesture guide:** Persistent or toggleable display of gesture vocabulary
- **Feedback mechanisms:** Visual and/or audio confirmation of gesture recognition
- **Error handling:** Graceful handling of ambiguous or unrecognized gestures with appropriate user feedback

The interaction flow is designed to be simple and discoverable, allowing users to learn the gesture vocabulary quickly and operate the system with minimal cognitive load.

4. Tools and Environment

Development Technologies:

- **Programming Language:** Python 3.x (selected for its extensive computer vision and GUI libraries)
- **Computer Vision Framework:** OpenCV (cv2) for video capture, image processing, and frame manipulation
- **Hand Tracking Library:** MediaPipe Hands (Google's machine learning solution for real-time hand landmark detection and tracking, providing 21 3D hand landmarks per detected hand)
- **Music Playback Integration:** Spotify Web API or local music library integration using appropriate Python libraries (e.g., spotipy for Spotify integration, or pygame/vlc for local playback)
- **User Interface Framework:**
 - Option 1: Tkinter (Python's standard GUI library) for a lightweight desktop application
 - Option 2: Web-based interface using Flask/FastAPI with HTML/CSS/JavaScript for cross-platform compatibility
- **Additional Libraries:** NumPy (numerical operations), gesture classification logic (custom implementation or scikit-learn for machine learning-based recognition)

Development Environment:

- **Operating System:** Desktop environment (Windows, macOS, or Linux)
- **Hardware Requirements:**
 - Standard webcam (minimum 720p resolution recommended)

- Adequate processing power for real-time video processing (modern multi-core CPU)
 - Audio output capability
- **Testing Environment:** Controlled indoor setting with consistent lighting conditions

Development Approach: The project will follow an iterative development methodology, beginning with basic gesture detection and recognition, followed by integration with music playback functionality, and concluding with user interface refinement and usability testing. Emphasis will be placed on interaction design principles, ensuring that the gesture vocabulary is learnable, memorable, and efficient for common music control tasks.

Expected Outcomes and HCI Relevance

This project addresses fundamental HCI research questions regarding natural user interfaces, gesture-based interaction, and touchless control systems. By implementing and evaluating a gesture-controlled music player, the project will provide insights into:

- The effectiveness of hand gestures as an alternative input modality for media control
- Design considerations for gesture vocabularies (learnability, memorability, distinctiveness)
- The importance of real-time feedback in gesture-based systems
- Usability trade-offs between traditional and gesture-based interfaces

The project aligns with contemporary HCI research on embodied interaction, accessibility, and context-aware computing, contributing to the understanding of how alternative interaction paradigms can enhance user experience in specific usage contexts.

Approval Requested: This project description is submitted for lecturer review and approval to proceed with implementation.